

Folk Models of Good and Bad Taste: A Computational Text Analysis

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Abstract

Sociologists have long debated the nature of “good” and “bad” taste, yet how lay individuals actually define these categories remains under-explored. Using open-ended survey responses, this research note applies BERTopic to inductively map folk cultural models of taste definitions and examples. I identify distinct cultural models for “good taste” (e.g., Subjectivity, Aesthetics, Fashion) and “bad taste” (e.g., Dislike, Poor Choices, Vulgarly). Chi-square cross-tabulations reveal that these cultural models form internally coherent cultural logics across both positive and negative evaluations. Furthermore, heatmaps mapping these cultural models onto 19 specific cultural domains reveal that while core domains like Music and Clothing are universally subjected to taste distinctions, moralized cultural models (e.g., citing Donald Trump or the Obamas) are associated with a heightened propensity to draw taste boundaries across nearly all domains.

1 Introduction

The sociological study of cultural stratification has traditionally focused on how cultural consumption patterns map onto social hierarchies (Bourdieu, 1984). However, theoretical conceptualizations of “good” and “bad” taste are rarely compared against how everyday people implicitly define these constructs, although some recent interview-based work has begun to plumb this subject (Haak and Wilterdink, 2019; Jarness and Friedman, 2017). Do people view good taste as an aesthetic achievement, a moral disposition, or mere consensus with dominant trends? Better understanding these folk models of taste can provide vital insight into the contemporary boundaries of cultural inclusion and exclusion.

2 Research Questions

This research note is guided by three primary research questions:

1. What are the distinct, latent cultural models that lay individuals use to define and provide examples of “good taste” and “bad taste”?
2. How do cultural models of good taste relate to cultural models of bad taste? Are they structurally coupled into broader cultural logics?
3. How do these taste cultural models map onto specific cultural domains (e.g., beer, classical music, wrestling)?

3 Methods

Data for this study are drawn from an open-access dataset originally collected by Bonard et al. (2024). In this study, researchers collected data from a representative sample of the US adult population ($N = 297$) through the *Prolific Academic* platform. After screening for data quality using four attention checks, the final sample comprised 241 participants (124 men, 114 women, 3 other; $M_{age} = 44.92$, $SD_{age} = 16.12$). In their survey, respondents were asked whether they distinguish between good and bad taste in their daily lives. The overwhelming majority of the sample (93%, $N = 224$) answered affirmatively. This subset was then asked to provide brief, open-ended definitions and concrete examples of both concepts.

To analyze these short, unstructured participant-level text responses (hereafter “documents”), I used **BERTopic**. During preprocessing, domain-specific survey artifacts (e.g., “good,” “bad,” “taste,” “don’t”) were removed from each document because these words—mostly paraphrasing the original question—were overwhelmingly common across documents and thus did little to differentiate them. We also remove common English stop words from each document (e.g., the, it, is, do, etc.). The algorithm was optimized for each of the four text fields independently to prevent vocabulary blurring. Finally, cross-tabulations and domain-distinction Likert scale heatmaps were generated to examine the coherence of these classifications.

4 Results

4.1 Cultural Models of Taste

The BERTopic models identified distinct cultural models for definitions and examples. For **Good Taste**, respondents defined the concept primarily through *Similarity/Subjectivity* (homophily), *Aesthetics*, or *Style/Quality*. When asked for concrete examples, the clusters were much richer, featuring groups who cited *Fashion/Decor* (friends and spouses), *Refinement/Art* (creators like Steve Jobs), *Musical Knowledge*, or even specific public figures representing class like *The Obamas*.

Topic	Count	Name	Keywords
-1	32	-1_fashion_trendy_style_appreciate	fashion, trendy, style, appreciate, clothes, opinion, music, say, art, prefer
0	113	0_say_mean_usually_subjective	say, mean, usually, subjective, food, quality, enjoy, sense, certain, similar
1	62	1_art_appreciate_choices_shows	art, appreciate, choices, shows, look, enjoy, understand, pleasing, appealing, gaudy
2	16	2_interact_services_selection_look	interact, services, selection, look, style, way, choices, goods, interests, dress

Table 1: Good Taste Summary Table

Topic	Name	Example Responses
0	0_say_mean_usually_food	• ‘good taste in my opinion would mean that it is a logical and understandable as to why they like it. Their likings is well received from the population.’ • ‘In reality, I’ve learned good taste and bad taste are subjective. If nowadays I use that expression, would be most likely as a joke. I can’t define good or bad taste for other people.’
1	1_art_choices_appreciate_shows	• ‘When I agree with their design opinions and choices. It’s when I think what they would like in their home or what they wear is something appreciable to myself.’ • ‘I think that they make good, stylish choices based on the type of aesthetic that I myself appreciate. They also think in creative ways that complement their choices as a whole.’
2	2_interact_services_selection_style	• ‘To me, it means someone has a good understanding of what is visually or otherwise appealing. Or that it is socially the most appealing.’ • ‘Generally it means I agree with their aesthetic choices and they choose things that look good.’

Table 2: Representative Documents for Good Taste Definitions

For **Bad Taste**, respondents defined it through *Subjective Dislike*, *Poor Choices/Lack of Effort*, *Tackiness/Gaudiness*, *Low-Brow Media*, or *Poor Manners/Immorality*. Concrete examples similarly ranged from *Poor Fashion*, *Derivative Media* (e.g., formulaic filmmakers), to specific instances of *Vulgarity* (often citing Donald Trump).

Topic	Name	Example Responses
0	0_clothes_look_friend_dresses	• <i>‘I think my friend Krystal has good taste, because she decorates her house simply yet with pretty pieces that she’s been handed down or she’s gotten from small independent places. She doesn’t just go to Hobby Lobby and get the decor that the rest of us have.’</i> • <i>‘I think my friend has really good taste in fashion, I like his sense of style. I could wear what they wear and look good in them as well. I don’t have to wear everything they wear, but either way I still think they have good taste.’</i>
1	1_art_time_audience_way	• <i>‘This person has good taste because they have spent a lot of time consuming media from this particular topic and is able to identify strengths, weaknesses and areas of improvement for participants in the subject. They do not pass quick judgement and their opinions are held in esteem.’</i> • <i>‘I can’t think of someone like that off the top of my head.’</i>
2	2_friend_best_lot_friends	• <i>‘My best friend has very good taste, he really puts a lot of effort into making sure that things fit together in an appropriate way and cater to his strengths and weaknesses appropriately. He also does a lot of research online to see other people’s tastes and tries to incorporate those things into his own stylistic choices.’</i> • <i>‘I think my best friend has good taste in art and food. They pay close attention to the subtle details that the artists put into their work and can appreciate the level of depth and details that the artist had. Also in food, while fine dining is not in itself good taste, I think my friend can appreciate unique flavor combinations that most people just hate while they haven’t tried them first.’</i>
3	3_music_personal_consider_opinion	• <i>‘A friend of mine who doesn’t like listening to metal music but who understands the value in it. He also understands the difficulty in performing and how there is a type of music for everyone. This is an example where I would completely disagree with their opinion, but that doesn’t necessarily mean they have bad taste. They also enjoy other forms of music that I also enjoy.’</i> • <i>‘I think taste depends on each person. Someone who has good taste in music is my sister who will listen to it, regardless of who thinks it is good or not.’</i>
4	4_movies_shows_son_enjoy	• <i>‘I think my father fits this description. He generally likes quality tv shows, movies and animation. He likes good music and is not afraid to expand and watch/listen to new genres.’</i> • <i>‘I think my grandmother has good taste in shows. She watches reliable news outlets. She also watches murder mysteries and some police drama shows, as well as movies about historical events. She doesn’t watch Ancient Aliens, Finding Bigfoot, or anything else conspiracy or cryptid based.’</i>
5	5_obama_michelle_way_live	• <i>‘The Obamas. Tastefully dressed, well presented, well read, educated. I haven’t seen inside their house to see what their furniture tastes are like!’</i> • <i>‘Michelle Obama. She’s elegant, coherent, well versed,</i>

Topic	Count	Name	Keywords
-1	38	-1_quality_poor_dont_art	quality, poor, dont, art, understanding, clothing, usually, value, negative, content
0	106	0_say_dont_likes_example	say, dont, likes, example, usually, does, different, mean, doesnt, opinion
1	61	1_dont_choices_care_make	dont, choices, care, make, maybe, poorly, gaudy, art, value, andor
2	18	2_loud_sense_colors_shows	loud, sense, colors, shows, qualities, character, boo, drama, bold, similar

Table 4: Bad Taste Summary Table

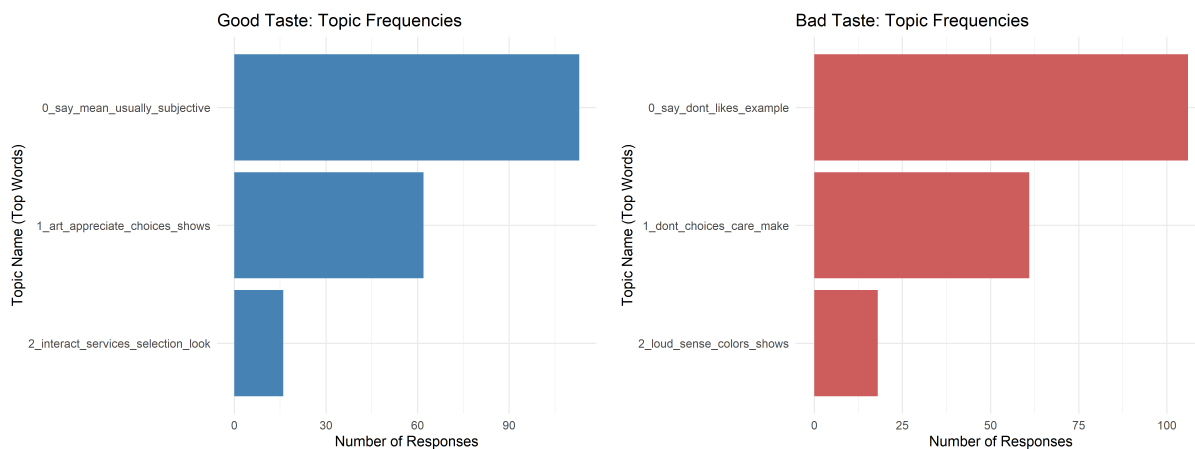


Figure 1: Topic Frequencies for Good and Bad Taste (Definitions)

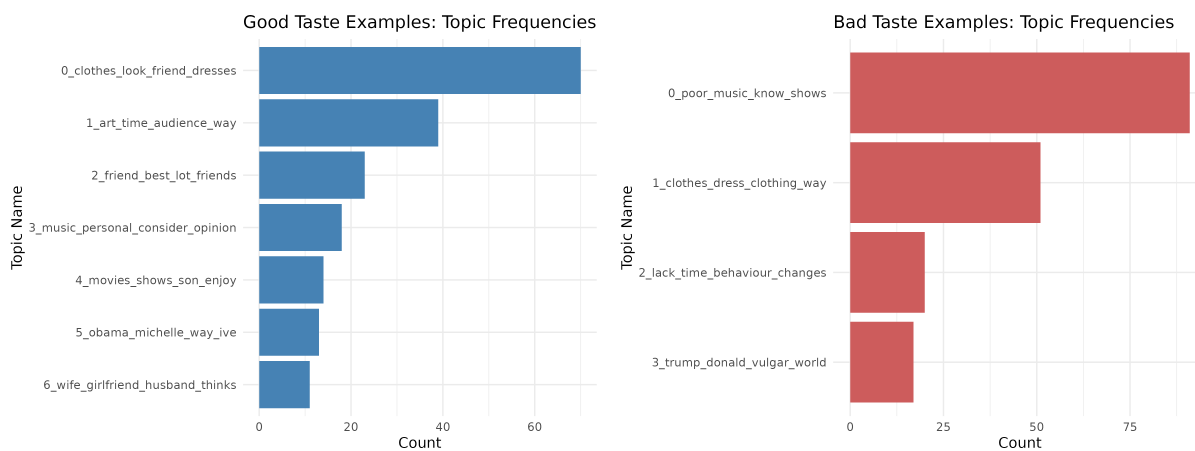


Figure 2: Topic Frequencies for Good and Bad Taste (Examples)

Topic	Name	Example Responses
0	0_say_art_likes_does	• ‘The opposing view is not necessarily equal to bad taste in this scenario. Bad taste would be when I would deem someone having an unreasonable take or opinion on a given topic.’ • ‘When I say bad taste, it means that the person does not pay attention to the finer details of things and just decide to follow everyone without knowing why they picked it. For example, in fashion, people would pick the worst outfits that despite having unique patterns, they did it in a way that it looks cheap and does not elevate their look.’
1	1_choices_care_make_unappealing	• ‘I think that the person doesn’t think very hard about their decision in regards to aesthetic choices. I also think that they may not think about how individual pieces of their choices fit together to form a big picture, as well as never evolving their taste.’ • ‘Thy just like something for face value and not how it holds up in the long run’
2	2_loud_sense_bold_boo	• ‘any american teen’ • ‘a person who is not very smart’
3	3_music_movies_enjoy_shows	• ‘When someone has a bad taste they are probably focused on a single genre and completely ignore everything else. Usually they would watch poorly scripted shows or movies, reality tv, etc.’ • ‘When someone has "bad taste" I tend to think they enjoy media, books, and food made for the lowest common denominator. They are easily entertained by things like reality television, Michael Bay films with tons of explosions, and their favorite music is whatever the latest generic popular rap/pop artist has on the radio.’
4	4_usually_quality_acceptable_racist	• ‘It means that they don’t like what is socially acceptable, or don’t have an understanding of what is acceptable.’ • ‘It means something looks horrible on them or the music isn’t to their liking. It depends on the person and who you’re explaining it to. Each person has their own taste.’
5	5_poor_violence_manner_humor	• ‘usually trashy, bad humor, poor technique, poor quality’ • ‘If someone finds humor by making fun of someone. If there is violence, or abuse.’

Table 5: Representative Documents for Bad Taste Definitions

Topic	Name	Example_Responses
0	0_poor_music_know_shows	• <i>‘A friend of my husband has bad taste in a way that he watches porn a lot and watches a lot of obscene stuff. I don’t see any way that this could be seen as something else other than bad taste. There is nothing artistic or knowledgeable about what he watches.’</i> • <i>‘Subjectively speaking, my brother Daniel likes a lot of raeggaeton music, which I personally dislike. The substance of the lyrics and the rhythms are not my cup of tea.’</i>
1	1_clothes_dress_clothing_way	• <i>‘This person is good with tools, but unfortunately not good with designing her living space. Has toolboxes everywhere and keeps the windows shuttered so that it’s dark inside. Cluttered space with bland furniture. A wooden spool for a table...’</i> • <i>‘I have a friend with poor taste. She pays little to no attention to aesthetics and lives in a messy, cluttered space with many clashing design elements.’</i>
2	2_lack_time_behaviour_changes	• <i>‘this person is noisy, ill mannered ,without limits in behaviour’</i> • <i>‘Someone you makes impulse decisions or does something just to do it.’</i>
3	3_trump_donald_vulgar_world	• <i>‘Trump is a mean, selfish and has no respect on anyone but himself.’</i> • <i>‘Trump. He is gaudy, disgusting and uneducated. He is spiteful and childish.’</i>

Table 6: Representative Documents for Bad Taste Examples

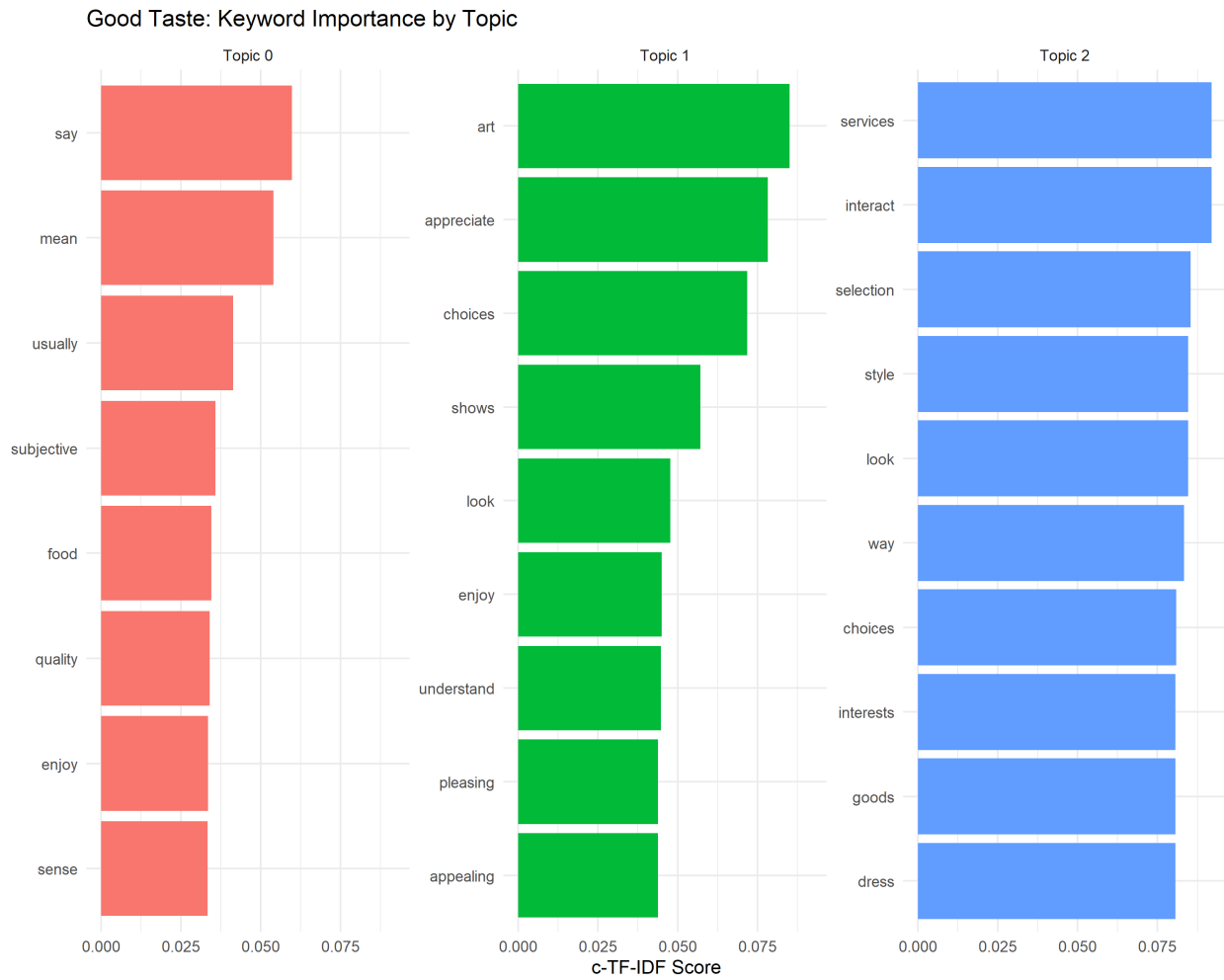


Figure 3: Keyword Importance (c-TF-IDF) for Good Taste Topics (Definitions)

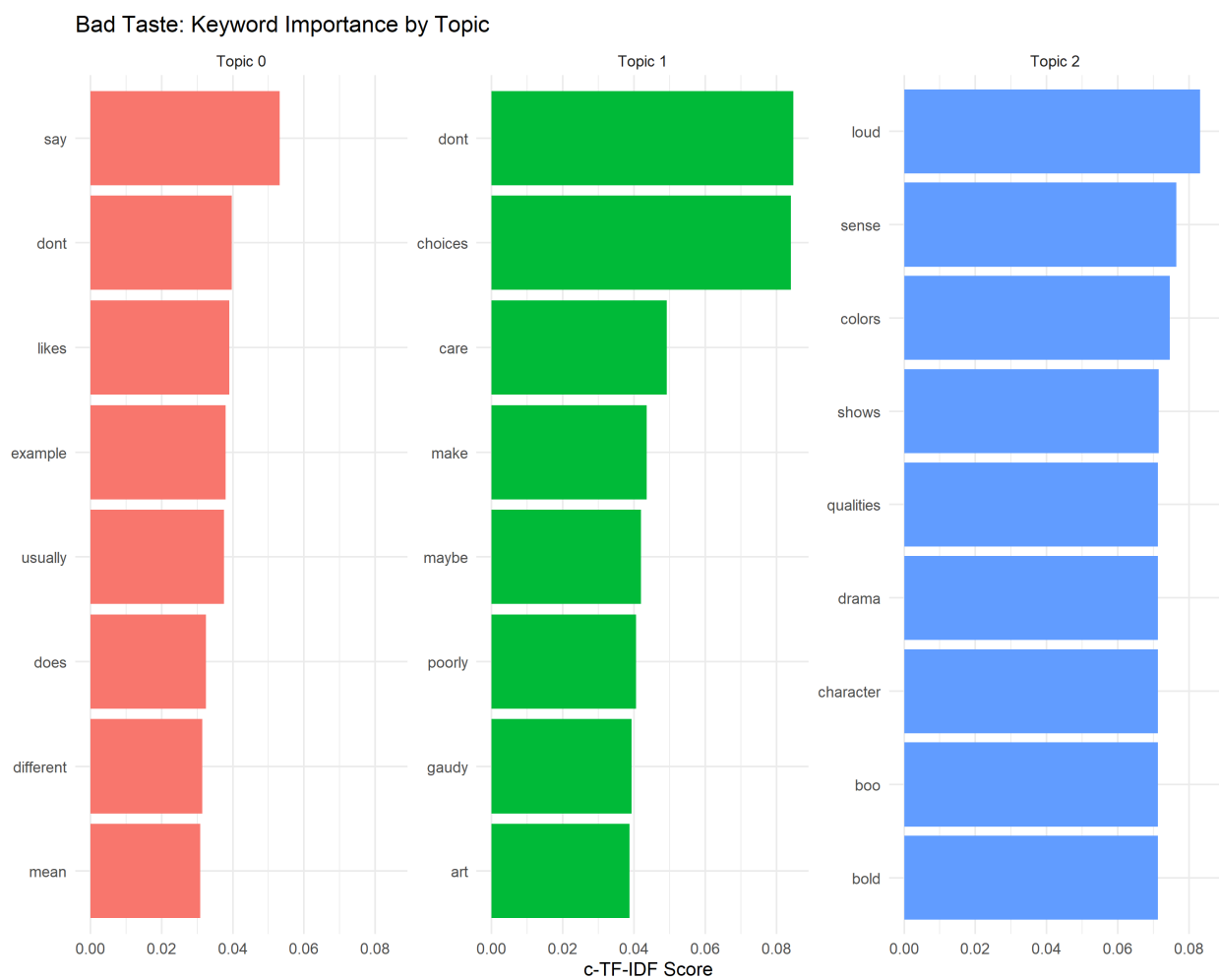


Figure 4: Keyword Importance (c-TF-IDF) for Bad Taste Topics (Definitions)

Good Taste Examples: Keyword Importance

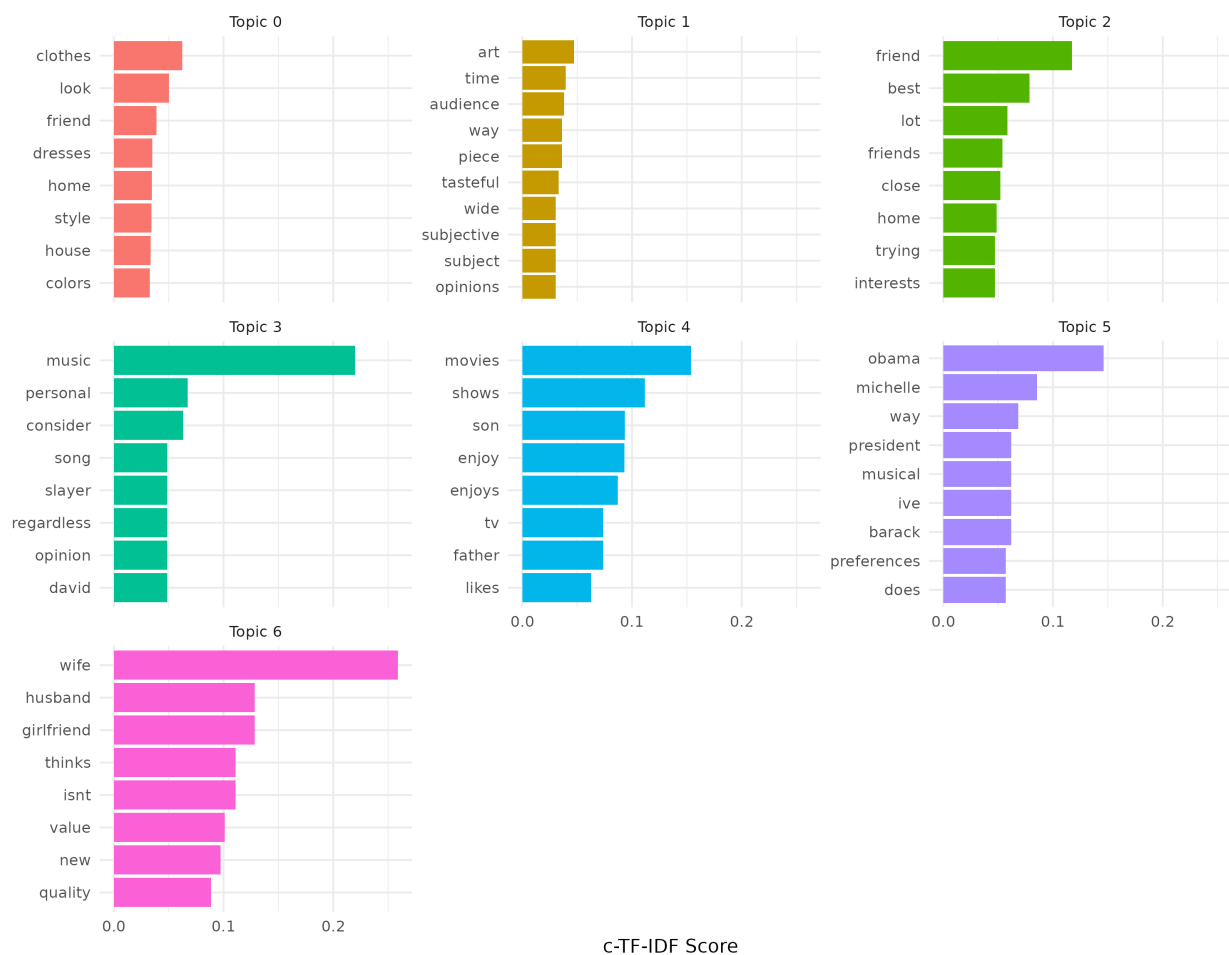


Figure 5: Keyword Importance (c-TF-IDF) for Good Taste Topics (Examples)

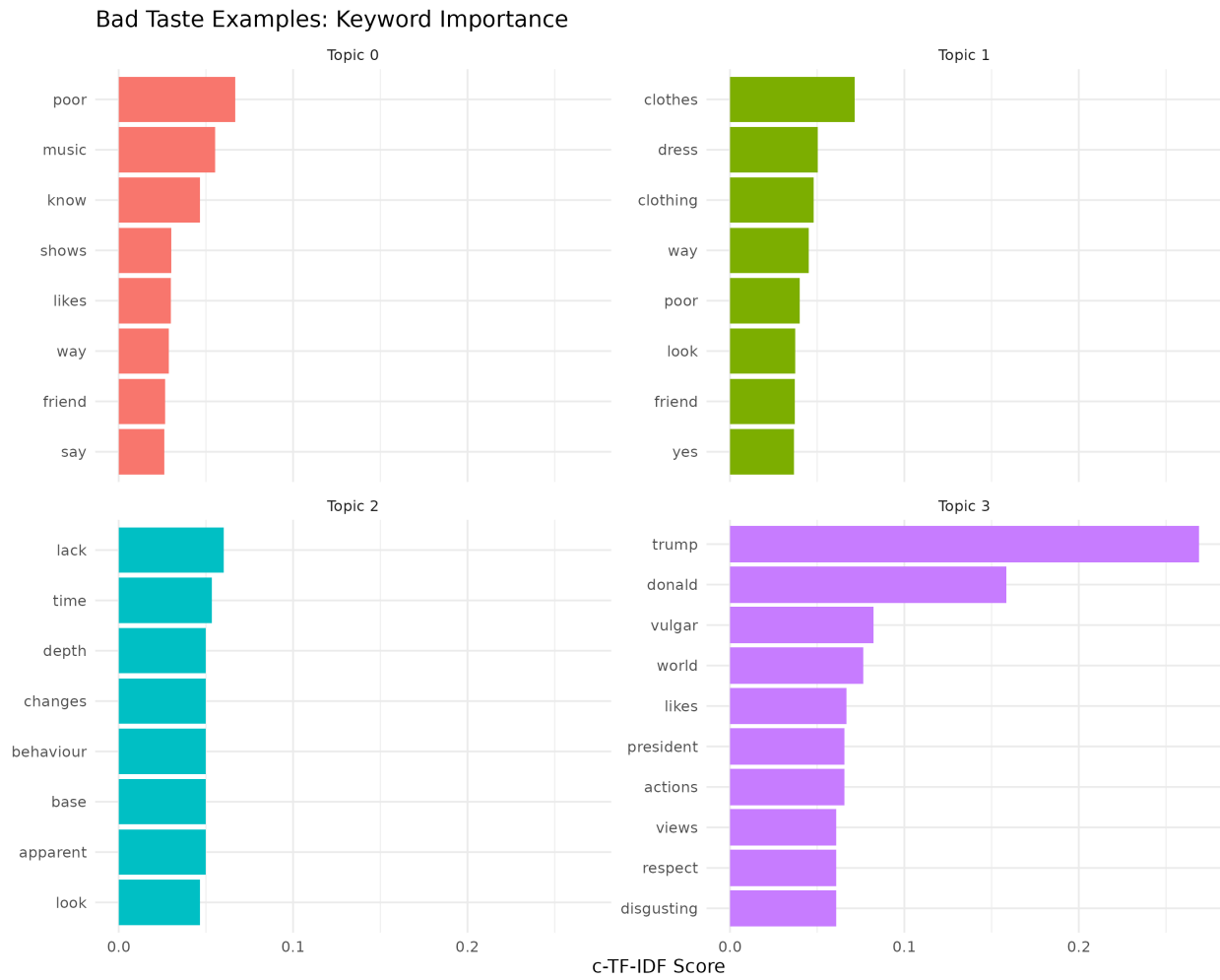


Figure 6: Keyword Importance (c-TF-IDF) for Bad Taste Topics (Examples)

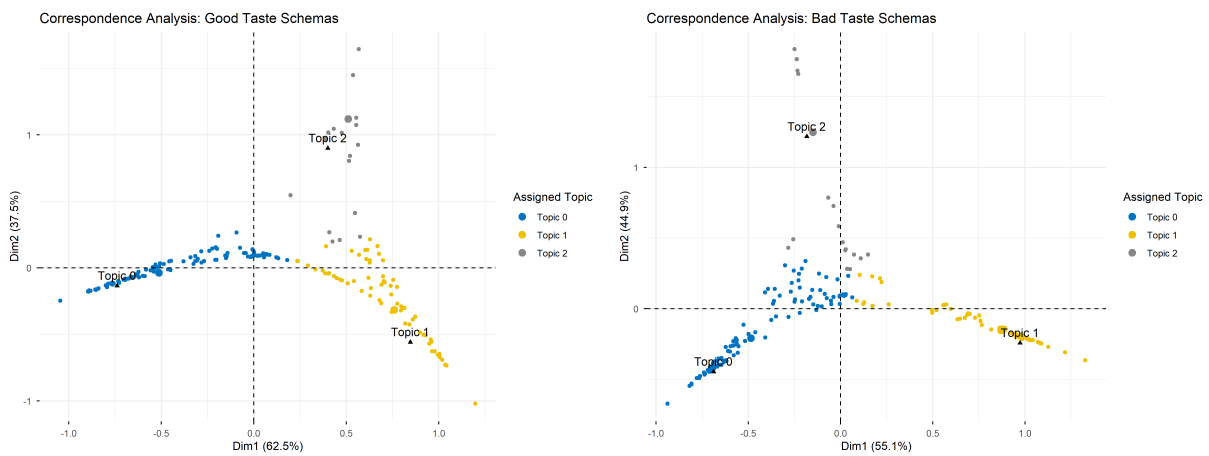


Figure 7: Correspondence Analysis of Taste Schemas (Definitions)

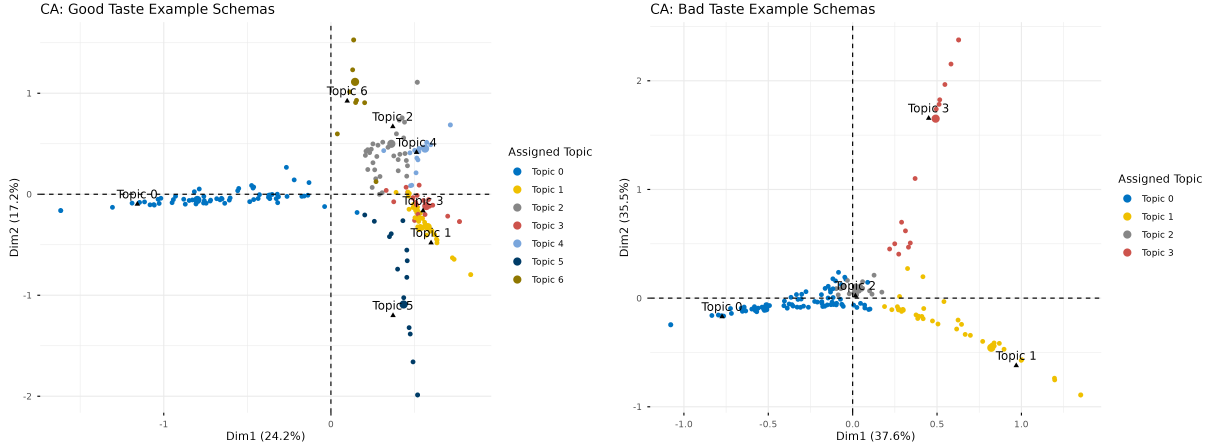


Figure 8: Correspondence Analysis of Taste Schemas (Examples)

4.2 Cross-Schema Cultural Logics

To test whether these cultural models are isolated or form coherent “logics,” I cross-tabulated respondents’ primary cultural models across the four questions. The associations are highly significant. For instance, a respondent’s definition of Good Taste strongly predicts their definition of Bad Taste ($\chi^2 = 111.60, p < 0.001$). Individuals who define good taste as subjective similarity overwhelmingly define bad taste simply as subjective dislike.

Similarly, the examples respondents choose are highly correlated ($\chi^2 = 99.01, p < 0.001$). Respondents who cite a friend’s “Fashion/Decor” as an example of good taste are highly likely to cite “Poor Fashion” as an example of bad taste. Respondents who point to “Refinement/Art” for good taste are much more likely to point to “Derivative Media” for bad taste. This symmetry indicates that people deploy consistent criteria—whether aesthetic, material, or subjective—across moral valences.

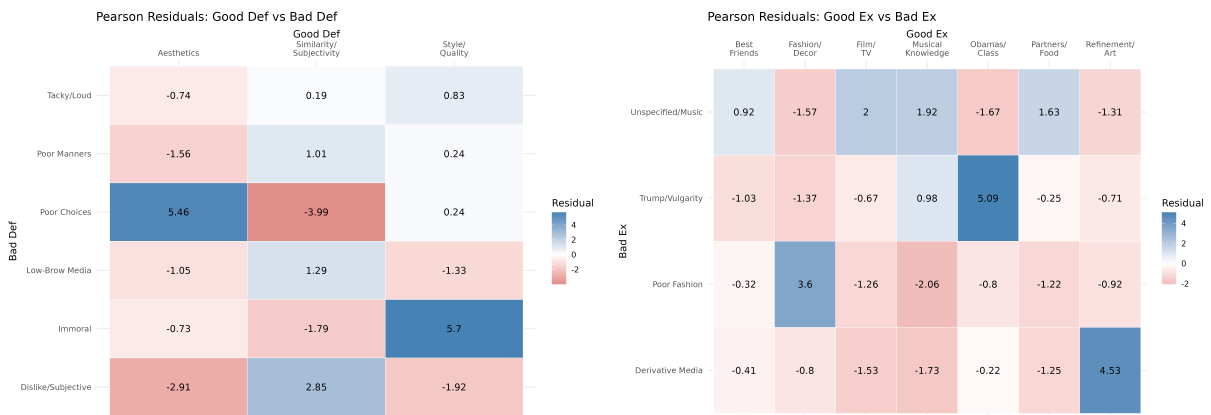


Figure 9: Pearson Residuals of Schema Correlation for Definitions (Left) and Examples (Right)

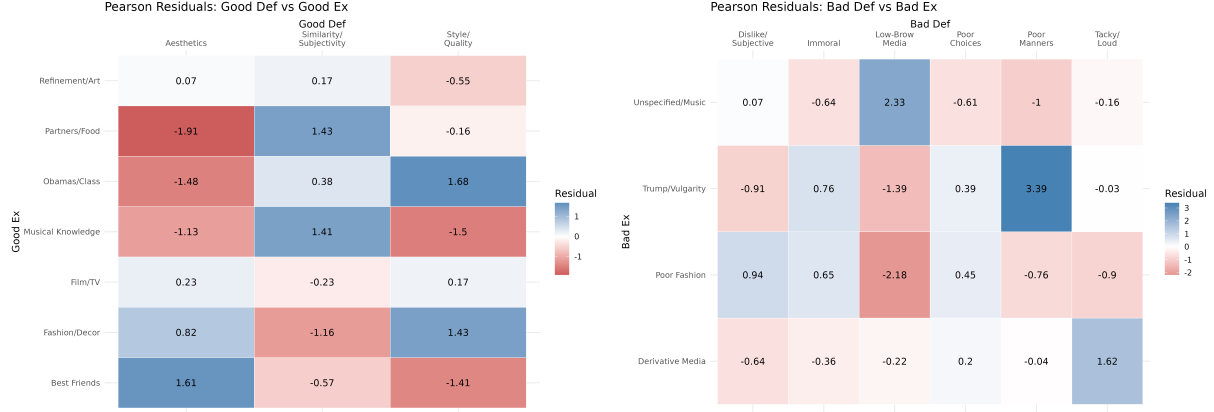


Figure 10: Pearson Residuals of Schema Correlation Between Definitions and Examples

4.3 Demographics

To examine whether cultural taste schemas are patterned by socio-demographic factors, I fit multinomial logistic regression models predicting respondents’ primary topic schema (across all four models) using their Age, Gender, Education, and Political Orientation. The Wald χ^2 tests are presented below.

4.4 Domain Distinction PCA and ANOVA

To analyze respondents’ propensity to draw cultural boundaries across domains without testing 19 individual domains simultaneously, I conducted a Principal Component Analysis (PCA) on the distinction ratings. The first dimension captures a general propensity to draw distinctions across all domains (as all variables load positively). The subsequent dimensions capture domain-specific clusters (e.g., separating traditional high-brow arts from pop culture or recreational activities).

I extracted the individual respondent scores for the first three PCA dimensions and ran One-Way ANOVAs to test whether mean scores differ significantly depending on the respondent’s topic schema assignment. The results demonstrate how different schemas of taste correspond to distinct configurations of cultural boundary-drawing.

4.5 Domain Distinction Heatmaps

Respondents were also asked to rate whether it “makes sense” to distinguish good and bad taste across 19 different domains (from -3 = Strongly Disagree to +3 = Strongly Agree).

Visualizing these scores as heatmaps across our topic clusters reveals several structural universals: regardless of the schema, respondents highly agree that taste distinctions make sense for **Clothing, Interior Design, Movies, Music, and Paintings**, while rejecting taste distinctions for **Car Races and Wrestling**.

However, there is critical variance in boundary intensity. Respondents whose examples of good taste clustered around *The Obamas/Class*, and whose bad taste clustered around *Trump/Vulgarity*, reported much higher propensity to draw taste distinctions across almost

Model	Predictor	Wald χ^2	Df	<i>p</i> -value
Good Taste Def	Age	2.96	2	0.2274
Good Taste Def	Gender	1.74	2	0.4198
Good Taste Def	EducationLevel_Coded	0.08	2	0.9630
Good Taste Def	Political	1.24	2	0.5380
Bad Taste Def	Age	7.17	5	0.2085
Bad Taste Def	Gender	1.91	5	0.8619
Bad Taste Def	EducationLevel_Coded	5.64	5	0.3428
Bad Taste Def	Political	4.86	5	0.4329
Good Taste Example	Age	12.90	6	0.0447
Good Taste Example	Gender	4.21	6	0.6480
Good Taste Example	EducationLevel_Coded	9.36	6	0.1544
Good Taste Example	Political	8.14	6	0.2280
Bad Taste Example	Age	5.90	3	0.1165
Bad Taste Example	Gender	0.37	3	0.9463
Bad Taste Example	EducationLevel_Coded	3.29	3	0.3494
Bad Taste Example	Political	2.88	3	0.4111

Table 7: Multinomial Logistic Regression Wald Tests for Topic Predictors

Dimension	Good Taste Def	Bad Taste Def	Good Taste Ex	Bad Taste Ex
Dim1	0.94 (0.393)	0.24 (0.943)	1.68 (0.127)	1.85 (0.138)
Dim2	1.48 (0.229)	1.80 (0.115)	0.23 (0.966)	1.74 (0.160)
Dim3	1.91 (0.150)	0.56 (0.731)	1.22 (0.298)	1.95 (0.123)

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$

Table 8: ANOVA Results: Mean Differences in PCA Dimensions of Distinction Ratings by Topic Schema.

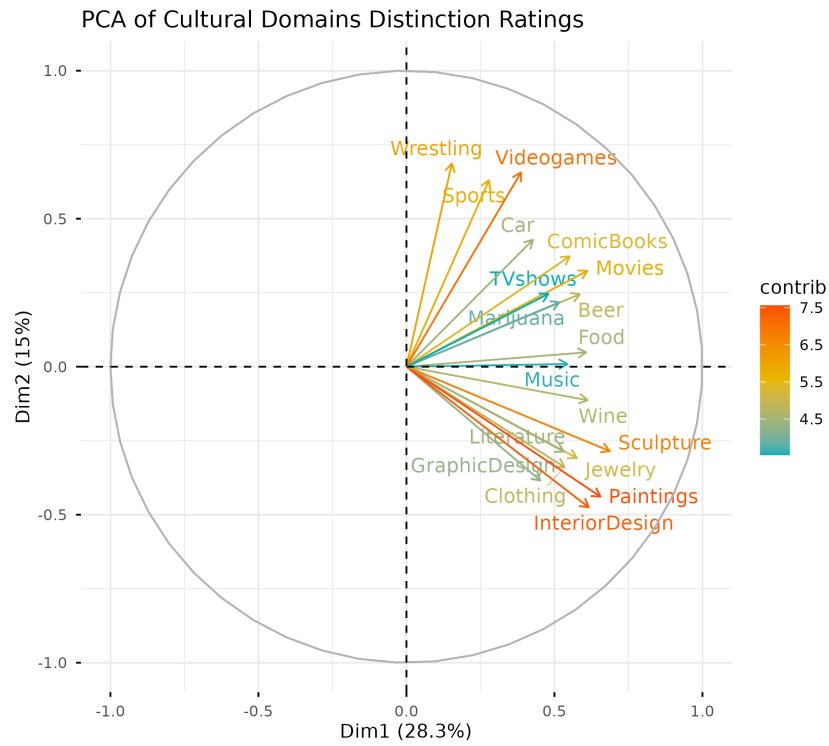


Figure 11: Correlation Circle of Distinction Domains with Principal Components

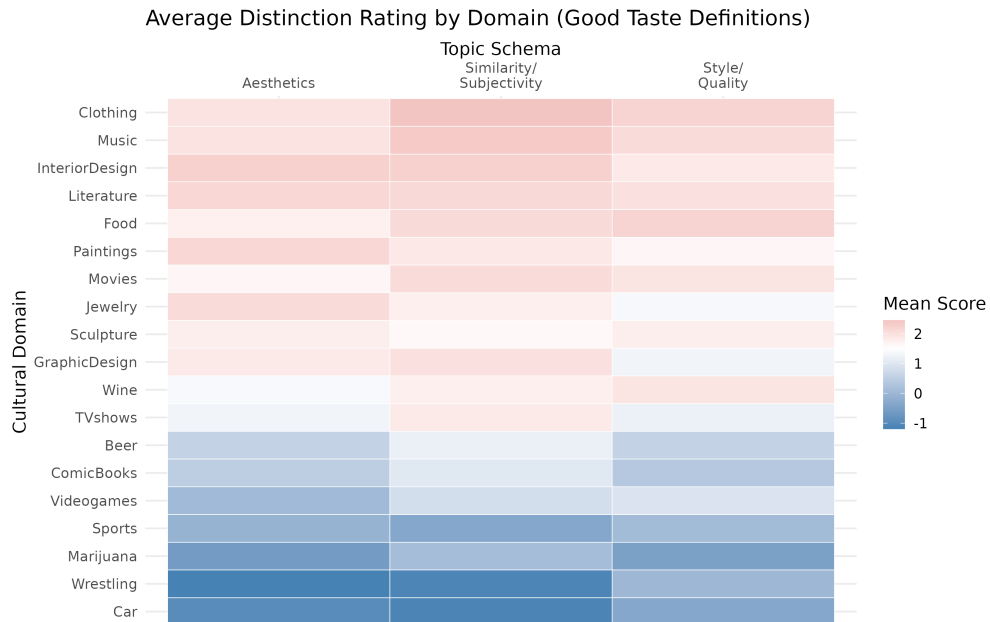


Figure 12: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Good Taste Schema (Definitions)

Domain	Good Taste Def F (p_{adj})	Bad Taste Def F (p_{adj})	Good Taste Ex F (p_{adj})	Bad Taste Ex F (p_{adj})
Beer	1.48 (0.469)	0.40 (0.977)	1.04 (0.767)	0.78 (0.565)
Car	1.09 (0.535)	1.18 (0.952)	0.58 (0.837)	1.55 (0.530)
Clothing	2.19 (0.469)	1.12 (0.952)	0.94 (0.767)	1.10 (0.530)
ComicBooks	1.59 (0.469)	0.16 (0.977)	0.87 (0.767)	2.09 (0.450)
Food	1.08 (0.535)	0.17 (0.977)	1.34 (0.767)	1.18 (0.530)
GraphicDesign	1.52 (0.469)	0.17 (0.977)	0.69 (0.781)	1.00 (0.530)
InteriorDesign	0.68 (0.642)	0.93 (0.952)	0.83 (0.767)	1.32 (0.530)
Jewelry	1.42 (0.469)	0.44 (0.977)	1.02 (0.767)	2.00 (0.450)
Literature	0.08 (0.920)	2.16 (0.612)	1.00 (0.767)	1.00 (0.530)
Marijuana	1.49 (0.469)	1.26 (0.952)	0.69 (0.781)	0.16 (0.923)
Movies	1.01 (0.535)	0.84 (0.952)	2.99 (0.188)	1.42 (0.530)
Music	1.55 (0.469)	0.74 (0.952)	1.89 (0.767)	2.39 (0.450)
Paintings	0.55 (0.686)	0.63 (0.977)	0.38 (0.899)	1.46 (0.530)
Sculpture	0.18 (0.881)	1.58 (0.952)	1.26 (0.767)	0.37 (0.822)
Sports	0.39 (0.759)	1.16 (0.952)	0.81 (0.767)	3.77 (0.245)
TVshows	2.20 (0.469)	1.00 (0.952)	0.86 (0.767)	0.89 (0.532)
Videogames	1.91 (0.469)	0.73 (0.952)	0.37 (0.899)	0.95 (0.530)
Wine	0.74 (0.642)	0.21 (0.977)	1.06 (0.767)	1.21 (0.530)
Wrestling	2.25 (0.469)	3.18 (0.198)	1.39 (0.767)	2.07 (0.450)

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$ (Benjamini-Hochberg FDR corrected)

Table 9: One-Way ANOVA Results: Mean Differences in Domain Distinction Ratings by Topic Schema. Values are F -statistics with FDR-adjusted p -values in parentheses.

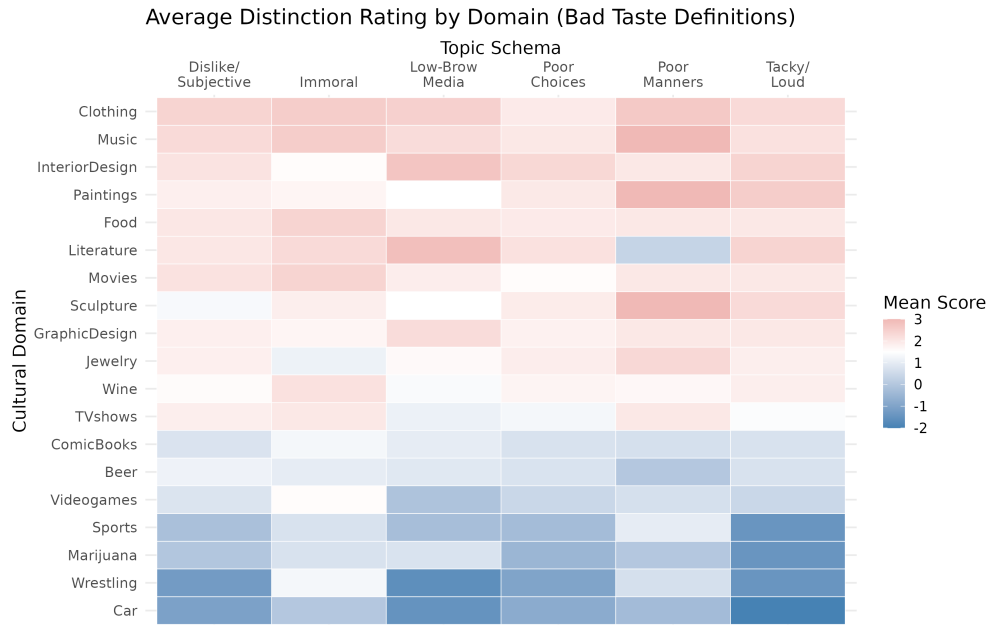


Figure 13: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Bad Taste Schema (Definitions)

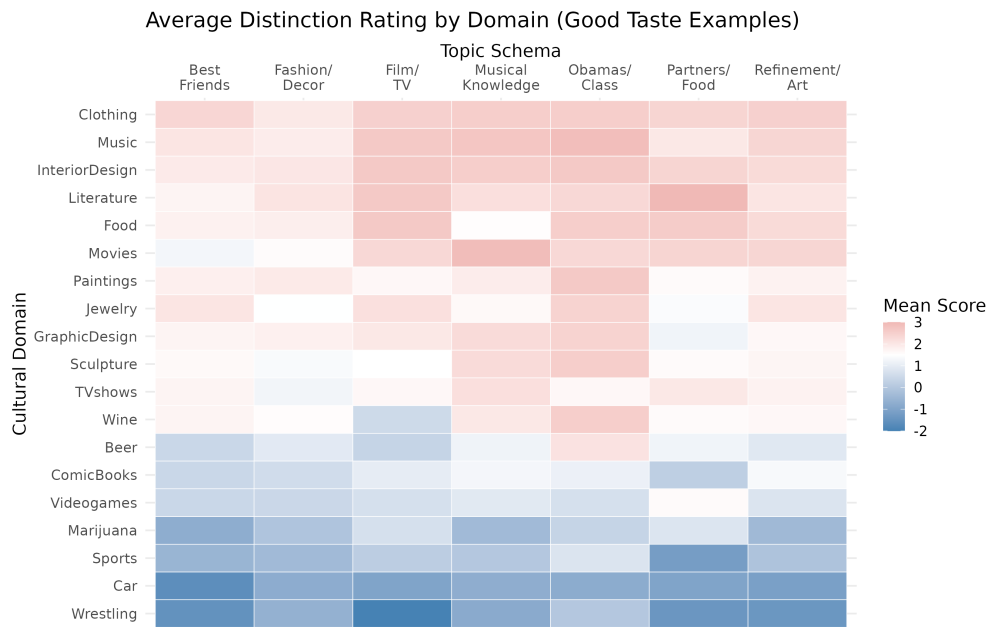


Figure 14: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Good Taste Schema (Examples)

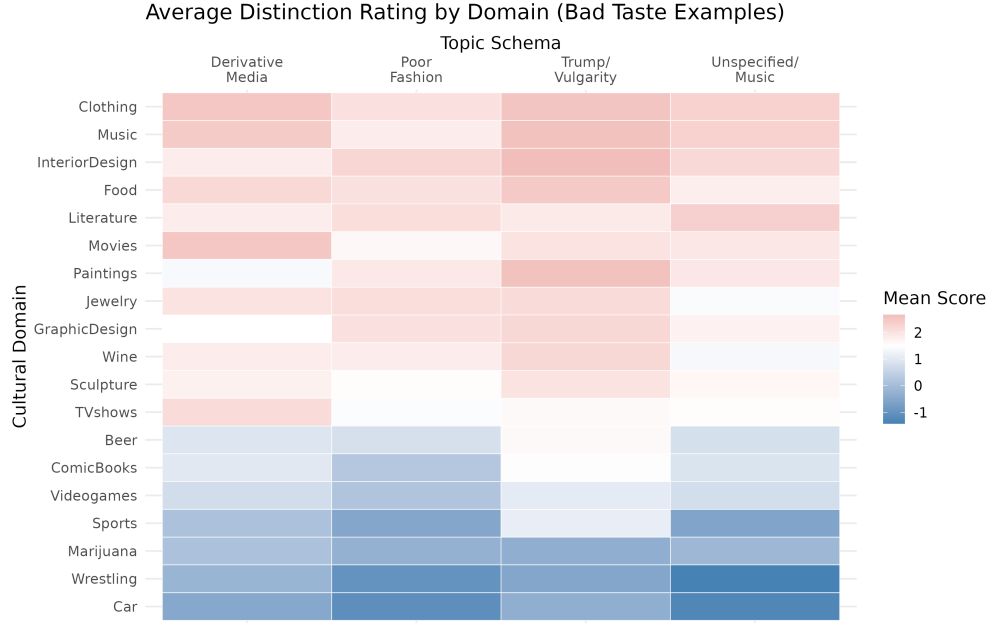


Figure 15: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Bad Taste Schema (Examples)

all domains, including peripheral ones like Food and Literature. This suggests that when folk models of taste become moralized or politicized, the boundaries of cultural distinction harden and expand across everyday life.

5 Discussion

This text-analytic exploration demonstrates that lay definitions of taste are not monolithic; they are multi-dimensional, spanning aesthetic, homophilous, and moral dimensions. Crucially, these dimensions are symmetrical. If an individual views good taste through the lens of objective aesthetic criteria, they evaluate bad taste using the exact same yardstick.

Furthermore, by mapping these inductively derived cultural models back onto structured survey variables, we observe that the specific folk model an individual uses dictates the breadth of their cultural boundary-drawing. Future research should expand on these findings by examining how these deeply held, qualitative cultural models of taste interact with actual patterns of structural inequality.

References

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